

Personal Statement

APPLICANT APP-008 | SOURCE RECORD 981

COMMON APPLICATION PERSONAL STATEMENT

Applicant	APP-008
Prompt	Reflect on an experience that contributed to personal growth or changed your understanding.
Word count	600
Processing designation	Human review only by default

The first sign that I needed a better plan was the page of crossed-out notes in front of me. I was working through a group assignment whose instructions left several possible directions, and each new idea seemed to create two more questions. My instinct was to keep moving and hope the direction would become obvious. Instead, I stopped, wrote the goal in one sentence, and listed what the group could actually verify. That small decision changed the project and, more importantly, changed the way I approach unfamiliar work.

I began separating assumptions from evidence. I asked each person to explain what they thought the assignment required, then combined the answers into a checklist. Some ideas were useful, some overlapped, and some had to be set aside. The process was slower at first, but it gave everyone a clear place to contribute. By the end of the meeting, the uncertainty had not disappeared; it had become organized enough for us to act.

That experience followed me into Research. I started paying attention to the work that happens before a visible result: preparing materials, confirming responsibilities, noticing who has not spoken, and checking whether a plan still makes sense after conditions change. I learned that leadership is not always the person with the quickest answer. Often it is the person willing to make the problem understandable and help others decide what to do next.

I also learned to become less protective of my first attempt. Earlier in high school, I sometimes treated revision as evidence that I had done something wrong. Gradually, I began to see feedback as information. A comment from a teacher could reveal a weak connection. A question from a teammate could show that my explanation made sense only to me. Revision became less about correcting a failure and more about making an idea usable by someone else.

This is one reason I am drawn to Applied Math. I enjoy the moment when scattered details begin to form a pattern, but I am equally interested in what happens after that pattern is found. Information matters when it helps someone understand a choice, improve a process, or ask a better question. I want to develop the technical and analytical foundation to do that work responsibly, while continuing to strengthen the communication skills that make the work useful.

The habits I value now are simple: define the question, document the process, invite another perspective, and be willing to change direction when the evidence requires it. These habits have helped me in classes, activities, and conversations where there was no obvious first step. They have also made me more patient with uncertainty. I no longer expect every worthwhile problem to arrive with complete instructions.

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In college, I hope to contribute to teams where people bring different strengths and where ideas improve through discussion. I will bring preparation, curiosity, and a willingness to complete the less visible work that keeps a project moving. I also expect to be challenged. I want classmates and professors to identify gaps in my reasoning, introduce methods I have not considered, and push me to explain my conclusions more clearly.

The crossed-out page from that first project was not a record of wasted effort. It showed the questions that eventually led to a stronger result. The lesson I carry forward is that progress does not require certainty at the beginning. It requires enough patience to examine the problem, enough humility to revise, and enough commitment to continue. That is the approach I hope to bring to the study of Applied Math and to the broader Riverview State community.